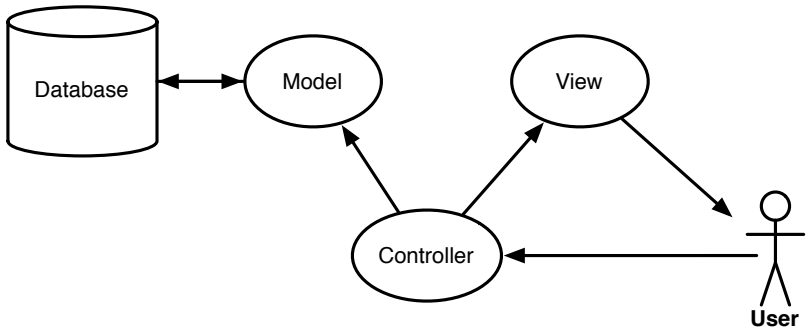
CHAPTER 11

Testing Rails Display Elements

Rails applications have a specific structure, which starts with the model-view-controller (MVC) pattern. The view layer has the responsibility of presenting data to the user, which in a server-side web application usually means generating HTML. Ideally, the view layer does this with minimal interaction with the model. The controller takes in information about the user request, contacts the appropriate parts of the model layer for data, and passes that information on to the view layer. The following is a simplified diagram of this pattern.



Rails has augmented this pattern with other standard layers for specific purposes. For example, ActiveMailer handles mail, ActiveJob handles background jobs, the router has its own DSL and may have some logic, and helpers straddle the line between display and view.

Each of these layers has tools designed to make them easier to test, though in many cases the best thing to do is put the bulk of the logic in a separate, ordinary Ruby object, test that, and use the Rails structure as minimally as possible. In this chapter I'll talk about the testing tools that Rails and RSpec provide for all of these different layers.